military commanders to put the army on highest alert. He also issued a warning to the Americans in a communiqué addressed to U Thant: “Cuba does not accept the vandalistic and piratical privilege of every warplane to violate our airspace. Therefore any warplane that invades Cuban airspace does so at the risk of meeting our defensive fire.” Castro meant what he said. He ordered fifty aircraft batteries to take positions across the country and start shooting down American airplanes beginning the next morning.[8]

Later in the day, Castro visited Soviet military headquarters to inform General Pliev of his order. Their meeting lasted the whole afternoon. Castro maintained that overflights could no longer be tolerated because they would make the Cuban and Soviet positions vulnerable when the invasion came. He asked Pliev to disperse his missiles. He and Dorticós then visited the Soviet ambassador, Aleksandr Alekseev. Castro wanted the Soviets to use the American violation of Cuban airspace as a pretext to declare that the weapons Kennedy was talking about were indeed in Cuba but under Soviet control. This was similar to the line considered by Khrushchev in his draft letter to Kennedy of October 24, which was supposed to be delivered by Georgii Bolshakov but was never dispatched because of Khrushchev’s change of mind.[9]

As day turned into evening and evening into night, Castro decided that his oral intervention with Pliev and Alekseev had been insufficient. He was getting more intelligence supporting his earlier belief that the Americans were coming. President João Goulart of Brazil informed him that he had forty-eight hours to dismantle the missiles or be attacked. Castro wanted Khrushchev to know what was going on. In the early hours of October 27, he went back to see Alekseev. The two drank beer and ate sausages as they discussed the content of the letter to be sent to Moscow. But the ambassador considered Castro’s information so urgent that he hastened to send word to Moscow even before the draft was completed. He telegraphed: “Castro is with us at the embassy and is preparing a personal letter for N. S. Khrushchev that will immediately be sent to him.” He then added: “In Castro’s opinion, the intervention is almost inevitable and will occur in approximately 24–72 hours.”[10]

It took Castro, with Alekseev’s help, close to three hours to complete the letter: he did not leave the Soviet embassy until 5:00 a.m. Castro